



Transforming Nepal's Maize Sector: **Innovation, Partnerships, and Investment**



Partners Forum and Field Day
5-6 June 2026 | Nepalgunj, Banke and Bardiya, Nepal

Background

Maize is the second most important cereal crop in Nepal after rice in terms of cultivated area and production. In the hill districts, maize plays a critical role in household food security, while in the Terai it is emerging as an industrial crop supplying raw materials for feed, food, silage, and other agro-industries creating rural employment opportunities.

Today, Nepal holds strong potential for investment in maize-based industries such as ethanol and starch production. By expanding domestic maize production and strengthening value chains, Nepal can reduce imports and potentially become an exporter of maize and maize-based products to neighboring countries.

Currently, maize is cultivated on approximately 916,044 hectares in Nepal, with an average productivity of 3.49 t/ha and an annual production of about 3.19 million tons. Despite this, domestic production remains insufficient to meet growing demand, resulting in annual imports of 400,000–500,000 tons of maize worth NPR 15–16 billion (USD 100–107 million). At the same time, substantial areas of land remain fallow across the Terai – particularly winter fallow land in the eastern and central Terai and spring fallow land in the western Terai. With improved irrigation, access to quality inputs, technical support, mechanization, and stronger market systems, these lands could be productively utilized to significantly increase national maize production.

The success of Maize Commercialization Model (MCM)

Recognizing these opportunities, [CIMMYT](#), in collaboration with the Ministry of Agriculture and Livestock Development, Nepal Agricultural Research Council, private sector actors, and farmer cooperatives, initiated the **Maize Commercialization Model (MCM)** in 2021 in the western Terai of Nepal. The model promotes market-oriented and research-driven sustainable production systems and cropping system diversification. Several innovations and service delivery models are being tested and scaled across Nepal's maize systems including improved seed and agronomic practices, climate-smart technologies, mechanization services, soil fertility management, market linkages, and private sector engagement models. The model also strengthens multi-stakeholder platforms, public-private partnerships, and contractual arrangements among cooperatives, agribusinesses, micro, small and medium enterprises, and industries to ensure quality grain supply and market linkage.

The initiative began in 2021 with 872 farmers from seven cooperatives cultivating 278 hectares in Banke and Bardiya districts. By 2026, the model has expanded to approximately 30,000 farmers across 15,000 hectares in nine districts. During this period, maize productivity is projected to increase from 5.5 tons per hectare to 7 tons per hectare (double the national average), while average additional income generated from previously fallow land is expected to rise from NPR 42,242 to NPR 138,158 per hectare.

Building on the demonstrated results and lessons learned, the Government of Nepal, through MOALD, integrated the MCM approach into its regular program beginning in 2025.

The Maize Commercialization Model (MCM), which began with 872 farmers in 2021, has now expanded to 30,000 farmers across 15,000 hectares in nine districts of Nepal.



Scaling up approach

The Department of Agriculture implemented the "Maize Commercial Model" conditional grant program in six *palikas* of three districts. Provincial and local governments have also prioritized scaling of the model in partnership with the private sector, including feed industries and farmer cooperatives. Nepal's feed mills are aiming to procure 70-80% of the maize from domestic sources in due course.

To further enhance competitiveness and sustainability of Nepal's maize sector, CIMMYT and partners are now strengthening the linkages between location-specific agricultural research, extension services, and industry engagement. Participatory technology testing, demonstrations, and innovation platforms have been initiated in the western hub at Khajura, Banke, in collaboration with NARC and with farmers in Banke, Bardiya, and Dang districts. These efforts are expected to accelerate technology dissemination and uptake, increase production and generate public and private sector investments to contribute towards achieving a vision of sustainable maize commercialization across 40,000 hectares by 2030. Such expansion could save Nepal approximately NPR 3.75 billion (USD 25 million) annually in maize imports while creating significant employment opportunities for inclusive growth.

The forum and field day will provide development partners and stakeholders with direct exposure to Nepal's evolving maize commercialization agenda. **Participants will engage with farmers, cooperatives, private-sector actors, and researchers to explore innovations and partnerships that drive productivity, resilience, market integration, and agricultural transformation in Nepal.**

Objectives

The event aims to:

- Showcase innovations and field-level implementation of maize commercialization models in Nepal
- Demonstrate integrated approaches linking research, extension, mechanization, markets, and private sector engagement
- Highlight experiences and lessons from farmers, cooperatives, local governments, and service providers
- Facilitate exchange between Government, development partners, researchers, and private sector actors
- Strengthen understanding of priorities and approaches supporting resilient and market-oriented maize systems in Nepal

Expected Participants

- Ministry of Agriculture and Livestock Development (MoALD)
- Ministry of Finance and provincial government representatives
- Nepal Agricultural Research Council (NARC)
- Development partners and international financial institutions
- Embassies and bilateral agencies
- Private sector representatives and agribusiness actors
- Farmer cooperatives and mechanization service providers

AGENDA

Day 1: Friday, 5 June 2026

Venue: Hotel Soaltee Westend, Nepalgunj, Banke District, Nepal

Strategic Briefing and Partner Dialogue

Setting the context for maize systems transformation in Nepal

Time	Session
15:30 - 16:00	Arrival, Registration and Networking Tea
16:00 - 16:20	Opening Remarks: MoALD & CIMMYT
16:20 - 16:40	Government Priorities for Nepal's Maize Sector Transformation
16:40 - 17:10	Innovation and Partnerships for Resilient and Commercial Maize Systems
17:10 - 17:40	Innovation Marketplace Walk featuring technologies and approaches from MoALD, NARC, CIMMYT, and partners
17:40 - 18:00	Orientation and Briefing for Day 2 Field Visits
19:00 - 21:00	Networking Dinner Reception

Day 2: Saturday, 6 June 2026

Venue/Locations: Khajura, Banke District and selected intervention sites in Banke and Bardiya districts, Nepal

Field Immersion and Stakeholder Exchange

Experience maize systems transformation from research to markets

Time	Session
7:30 - 9:00	Field Visit 1: NARC/ CIMMYT Research and Demonstration Sites in Khajura Focus areas: Hybrid maize performance, good agronomic practices, climate-smart agriculture, and soil fertility management
9:00 - 9:30	Tea Break
	Parallel Field Visits
9:30 - 12:30	Track A: Farmer and Service Delivery Systems <i>Visits to commercial maize farmers, mechanization service providers, and demonstrations of climate-smart and post-harvest technologies</i> Track B: Market Systems and Private Sector Investment <i>Visits to aggregation centers, traders, or feed mills, and other market actors involved in Nepal's maize value chain</i>
12:45 - 13:45	Lunch at Hotel Soaltee Westend, Nepalgunj
13:45 - 14:45	Stakeholder Reflection and Dialogue Session
14:45 - 15:00	Closing Remarks - MoALD, NARC & CIMMYT
16:00	Departure